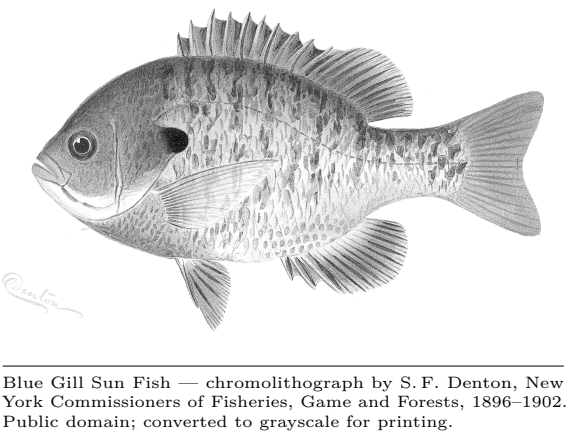




Tell it apart

A solid black ear flap with no coloured margin, a dark smudge at the rear base of the soft dorsal fin, a small mouth, and long pointed pectoral fins. Compare with the pumpkinseed, which has an orange-red spot on the flap and wavy blue lines on the cheek.

Size here

6–8 in is a good fish; a 9 in bluegill is a genuine trophy and worth releasing so it keeps breeding.

Spawn

67–70 °F, late May into June, in dense colonies of saucer-shaped beds on sand or gravel in 1–4 ft. You can see the beds from the boat and often smell them.

Eats

Insect larvae, small crustaceans, snails. A small mouth means small baits.

Season

|   |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| J | F | M | A | M | J | J | A | S | O | N | D |
| ■ | ■ | ■ | ■ | ■ | ■ | ■ | ■ | ■ | ■ | ■ | ■ |

Time of day

|      |     |      |       |
|------|-----|------|-------|
| Dawn | Mid | Dusk | Night |
| ■    | ■   | ■    | ■     |

Where

- Pine

Spots **6** (west bay) and **1** on the beds in June, then out to the deep weed edge at **5** — 12–18 ft — for the rest of the summer. Bluegill on Pine go deeper than most people expect.
- North

Spots **1** and **7**, and the weed flats generally. 4–10 ft.
- Winter

Basin edges and remaining green weed at 10–20 ft. Bays **6** on Pine, **1** on North.

How

- The rig

A slip bobber, a small split shot, and a size 8 or 10 hook, *see the slip bobber sheet*. Set the depth so the bait rides just above the weed tops.
- Bait

A piece of nightcrawler — not a whole one — a waxworm, a leaf worm, or a small leech. Bluegill have small mouths and will strip a big bait without ever getting hooked.
- Artificial

A 1/32 oz jig with a small plastic tail, or a small foam spider on a fly rod during the June bed period.
- Line

4lb. Anything heavier telegraphs badly on a small float and costs you bites.
- With a child

This is the fish. Anchor over a bed in June, use a fixed bobber a foot or two deep, and expect constant action. Barbless or pinched barbs make unhooking fast and safe.

Fish the beds gently

Bedding bluegill are easy to catch and easy to strip out of a bay. Take a meal, not a cooler. The biggest males guard the beds, and removing them all is how a lake ends up full of stunted four-inch fish.

Regulations on these waters, 2026–27. Panfish: 25 per day in total, open all year, no minimum length. These change; only the Wisconsin DNR’s current publication for this exact water body is authoritative.